

Sentinels of the Dawn

Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration
Our Lady of the Angels Monastery
Troyes, France

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Coming Home For Christmas

Often we think of Christmas as a time for coming home: college kids return during winter vacation; grandparents invite everyone to their place for a traditional feast; friends reunite to catch up on the latest news after not seeing one another for several months. Indeed, Christmas is a time when we all return home, even if it is only through recalling past memories.

But on that first Christmas, it was a different story. The people that we hear about in the Gospel accounts of Jesus' Nativity were not in the comfort of their own homes...they were far from the familiar warmth and comfort that we seek in our own holiday celebrations.

We can think of Mary and Joseph. A couple who, in obedience to the imperial command, set out from their home in Nazareth to enroll in the tax registers of Joseph's hometown of Bethlehem. A pregnant woman on the point of childbirth and weary from a long journey. A husband desperate to find them some shelter and a place to rest – unwanted and unwelcome. This was the plight of those who were closest to our Lord at the very outset of His life. This was the reality of the world that God loved and wanted to enter and to change.



We can also think of the shepherds, who spent much of their lives away from home herding sheep on the hillside outside of town. They were not exactly the highest-class people in Bethlehem...but rather were considered outcasts because they were smelly and dirty from tending the sheep outdoors most of the time.

And lastly, we think of Jesus. He left what we might call His "comfort-zone" in Heaven to enter a world of uncertainty and strife – the reality of our world. God so loved the world that He would not simply leave us on our own with no one to guide us or to lead us. So He gave us His only Son.

Each of these players in the divine drama is in unfamiliar territory, lacking the comforts of their own homes, lacking the family around them that would make their difficulties seem manageable. And yet, something beautiful happens. They manage to create a home. In spite of what they don't have, they celebrate what they do have. Mary and Joseph probably expected that their new baby would be born in their home in Nazareth. But there they were, in a cold stable with animals around them! And somehow, Mary and Joseph make this stable into a home. As they gaze upon the newborn babe, wrapped in swaddling clothes, they realize that they are a family, because wherever the family is, there is home.

As for the shepherds, late into the night, they tended to their flock in the fields, their "home away from home". Suddenly, they receive a visitor – an angel appears to them, bringing good news of great joy of Christ our Savior's birth. The shepherds, shocked by what they have heard, make haste to see this wonder. Upon arriving at the stable, they bask in the warmth of the Holy Family's love, in the glow of the Infant's holiness.

And Jesus, the Word made flesh, knows that He is where He is meant to be, where the world needs Him to be. He is the hope of a troubled world, a world that makes a pregnant mother and her husband travel a long distance near her due date for a tax enrollment, a world that makes shepherds into outcasts, a world that makes a rude stable the only place available for a stranded family. They were all home, so to speak. Not the homes that they expected or planned for, but the homes that are part of God's Divine Plan.

Sometimes we are led to believe that the "perfect" Christmas is one in which the whole family gathers together, eating the familiar foods, singing traditional songs, recounting the stories we've heard a thousand times before. But perhaps the story of that first Christmas reveals to us the simple fact that home and family are what we make them with God's help. Home is the place where we enter into God's peace. Family is the people who teach us Christ's love.

As we make the Christmas narrative a part of our own lives, learning of people away from their homes, ordinary people who became part of an extraordinary story, one of the greatest lessons we can learn is that our truest home is not a place, it is in Christ. Our truest family is not only with those whom we simply have a biological connection, it is with those in whom we can see Christ, and who can see Christ in us. This is the powerful message of the Nativity story, one that challenges us to welcome into our hearts and to be born again; to allow His love to become incarnate in us and share it with others. Yes, Christmas is about Christ. It was always about Christ. It will always be about Christ. Where Christ is, that is Christmas...that is family....that is home.

A Time for Mercy



Some have called Pope Francis the "Pope of Mercy," and, indeed, mercy seems to be a constant theme for him. So it was no surprise when he inaugurated a Jubilee Year of Mercy, which began on December 8th and will end on November 20th, 2016, the feast of Christ the King.

In announcing the Year of Mercy, Pope Francis expressed his deep desire that we have the joy of rediscovering God's loving mercy for us and that we offer this same mercy to our brothers and sisters in concrete acts of love. Pope Francis tells us "How much I desire that the year to come will be steeped in mercy, so that we can go out to every man and woman, bringing the goodness and tenderness of God. May the balm of mercy reach everyone, both believers and those far away, as a sign that the kingdom of God is already present in our midst." (General Audience, December 2014)

It is true that if we want to love other people, we first need to know God's unconditional love for us. When we are convinced of God's love and mercy for us, we become much more loving, patient, forgiving and merciful with others. Sometimes, though, we have wounds in our hearts and we don't feel loved or worthy of God's love. Maybe we feel hurt by others, or we have been abused, rejected, abandoned or betrayed. How many of us suffer interiorly, due to conflicts, division and abandonment in our families or with others!

What if we sincerely presented our wounded, broken self to the Lord and asked for the grace to accept our fragility?What if our hearts were healed because we chose to forgive rather than "nursing" negative feelings? What if we allowed God's love and mercy to come to us through the sacraments, daily prayer and the people in our lives?What if we made a decision to love even if we are not loved in return?

Throughout this Jubilee Year of Mercy, an abundance of graces are offered to us. May we not miss out on this opportunity to be vessels of His Divine Mercy, receiving it and extending it to others. *Jesus, we trust in you!*





May Christ's peace reign in our world...

Following the tragic loss of so many lives during the recent terrorist attacks in Paris, our thoughts and prayers have been lifted up to God for the numerous men and women who died or were seriously injured. We pray also for their loved ones, during their time of sorrow and for an end to these senseless acts of hatred.



Throughout the month of November, we remembered in a special way all our deceased brothers and sisters- those among our religious communities and families as well as benefactors and friends of our Monastery. Before All Souls Day, each of our Sisters had the opportunity to either visit the tombs of our deceased Sisters, buried in the cemetery of Troyes or to go to Nogent-sur-Aube, where our founder, Father Bonaventure, is buried. Together as a Community, we also prayed before the tomb of our beloved foundress, Mother Marie de Sainte Claire, who is buried in our cloister garden.



During this Christmas season, let us pray for our brothers and sisters throughout the world who are persecuted for their faith, for those who are undergoing terrible suffering, due to war, injustice, and terrorism. May Jesus' coming as the Prince of Peace, be a source of hope and consolation to our broken world.

Protecting and praising God's Creation



In honor of the Day of Prayer for the "Safeguard of Creation" in September as well as for the Solemnity of our Holy Father Saint Francis, our Sisters gathered together the "fruits" of God's bountiful creation - flowers and vegetables from our gardens! The trays that our Sisters arranged were presented during Mass and placed before the altar. At the end of Mass, the faithful were invited to take one fruit and to..."taste and see the goodness of the Lord!"





Celebrating Consecrated Life

In dedicating 2015 as the Year of Consecrated Life, Pope Francis expressed three aims. First, to awaken religious to the great challenge of their call in the present, to renew their passion for the mission of Jesus, and to serve with the joy that comes from following Christ intimately. Secondly, to draw attention to the gift that consecrated life offers to the whole Church, and call the faithful to grateful awareness of what has been and is being given particularly by religious congregations. And thirdly, to encourage vocations to religious life, and to ask that the faithful pray for vocations and support those who are discerning such a call.

Through personal meditation and communal activities, each one of our Sisters has had several opportunities throughout the course of this year to reflect on her own vocation, and what it means to be dedicated to Christ and His Church. It has been said that God is never be outdone in generosity, and for us who have given ourselves entirely to God as vowed religious, it is safe to say that we learn a little more each day just how true this it. Granted, it is not an easy life, but a most rewarding one and we are grateful to have said yes to the invitation.



As the Dominican Order of Preachers enters into their Jubilee Year of celebrating 800 years of their foundation, our Community was blessed to have two of Saint Dominic's spiritual sons give us several spiritual conferences. During this year of Consecrated Life, we welcomed Father Eric Clermont de Tonnerre, op from Paris to our Monastery on three different occasions. He focused on the religious life and our holy vows. For our annual community retreat, which took place from November 28th-December 2nd, Father Bernard Senelle, op, from Strausbourg, accepted our invitation as retreat master. The theme of his conferences was "Walk in my presence and be faithful!"(Genesis 17:2). We are so grateful for the spiritual wisdom that we received from both priests, which is the fruit of their own response to God's call, their studies and their many years of living and serving in their own communities. May God be praised for these moments of grace in our life, and for those who help us to strive along the path of holiness...



Our "Frat" will soon be 2 years old!!!

A word from the members:



"It will soon be two years since our secular Franciscan Fraternity, under the patronage of St. Elizabeth of Hungary, has been in existence, uniting ourselves with the Poor Clare Monastery of Troyes.

If the first year was a time of discovery, the second year could be looked upon as a time of growth and strenghtening of our relationship. Fraternl bonds among the members continue to deepen. Each month we gather for a friendly time of exchange, in which we share a meal. Outside of our meetings, we remain prayerfully united with one another.

In September, we found ourselves among other members of each fraternity of our region for a meeting at the Basilica of Notre Dame de l'Epine. We spent a beautiful day together, during which our fraternity was offically recognized and enthroned.

At the threshold of our third year, we pray that we may continue to live ccording to the spirit of Saint Francis and Saint. Clare.. On the agenda for this upcoming year, we will continue reading together as a Fraternity the encyclical "Laudato si". The door of the Poor Clare Monastery, along with that of the Fraternity, is always open to you.

We wish you and your loved ones a most Blessed Christmas!"



Fundraising for Monastery renovations



Our annual Christmas sale was held on November 25th and 26th. Thanks to the creativity and hard work of several members of our Association, the large parlor of our Monastery was transformed into a little gift shop. This year our Sisters contributed to the sale in providing several items to be purchased. Sister Mary Rosalie, the head seamstress for our Community, along with her team of Sisters and other women who volunteer their time and talent, prepared many articles of clothing as well as lavender sachets. Thanks to an abundance of apples from our garden as well as those that we received from others, Sister Mary Germaine and the "Sister-peelers" made a delicious 100% bio juice, which was bottled, labeled and ready to purchase. All benefits from our Christmas sale will go towards assisting our Community with the large financial expenses needed for our next renovation project. It is our great hope to see this work get underway early in 2016. We wish to express our sincere thanks to our friends who prepared this event, all those who donated items for the sale, and those who came to shop. Your goodness and generosity are greatly appreciated. May God bless each one of you who contributed to the success of this event!

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Farewell Ma Belle

From time to time, our readers inquire about the latest adventures of our guard dog, Ma Belle. In early September, she closed her eyes for the last time. Old age (15 years) and some health problems had taken their toll. Despite the fact that we no longer hear her barking whenever someone rings the doorbell, or see her lying in one of her favorite spots when we pass through the courtyard, we have many good memories of the eight years that she spent with us, which we shall never forget...





The Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration
in Troyes, France
wish you and your loved ones
A MERRY CHRISTMAS
and many graces and blessings
for the New Year !